EASE OF LIVING REVOLUTION

Time was, our republic was renowned as a realm of fatalist resignation and arrested development. Many of us grew up accustomed to those affectionate barbs about how yesterday and tomorrow were linguistically indistinguishable for Indians. How IST stood for 'Indian Stretchable Time' and economic progress was expected at the bovine pace of the 'Hindu Rate of Growth'.

Today, these cruel chestnuts have largely vanished from the lexicon of clichés about India, and are being replaced by snappy shorthand about 'the world's fastest-growing major economy', 'India Inc.', governance dashboards, and yes, 'ease of living'. The makeover may have begun with the economic liberalisation of the 1990s that unchained (or began to) the economy and unleashed our productive potential on the world. Yet it's only more recently that our citizens at large have begun to experience—and enjoy—the fruits of this transformation. From the digital reinvention of our payment, entertainment and welfare systems to the galloping extensions in highways, housing and healthcare, and basic amenities. Like tap water on—well, on tap. In every home—the Jal Jeevan Mission's target for 2025. Similarly, the BharatNet programme is set to bring high speed internet to most of rural India through its sprawling pipeline of fibreoptic cables.

Thanks to this alchemy of digital technology, brick-and-mortar infrastructure and old-fashioned elbow grease, Indians are now experiencing the beginnings of a gentle 'ease of living' revolution, 25 examples of which are profiled in these pages. Its optimistic momentum promises to unite us in a republic of frictionless and speedy service delivery, travel and transactions. A better Bharat for all.